US PARATROOPER UNIFORM

Initially the subject of contension, the differences between the Airbornes' uniform and that of standard infantry were established more to mark out these elite units than for any practical purpose. The right to wear special boots and to "blouse" (puff out) their trousers were coveted Airborne privileges. Their distinctive dress led the 509th Infantry (Airborne) Battalion to be dubbed the "devils in baggy pants" by a German soldier at Anzio.

M2 paratrooper helmet
Issued in plain olive green, helmets were painted with camouflage by the owner. The "Gingerbread Man" was the emblem of the 509th Battalion.

"Gingerbread Man" emblem

Pocket with zips either side held M2 switchblade used to cut the soldier loose in emergencies

Collar left unsprayed

Helmet sprinkled with dried cork to dull the surface

D-ring chin strap holder

Badge kept covered when dropped at night

Camouflage applied by soldier

> "I SHALL SHOW OTHER SOLDIERS ... BY MY NEATNESS OF DRESS, BY MY CARE OF MY WEAPONS AND EQUIPMENT, THAT I AM A ... WELL-TRAINED SOLDIER."
>
> EXTRACT FROM THE PARATROOPER CREED

M1942 jump jacket
Jackets and trousers were issued in olive green and then spray-painted with camouflage at unit level. Uniforms were sprayed while on the body, the soldier covering his head with a cardboard box that left the collar unsprayed. Surplus bandoliers were chopped up and sewn inside the coat to make extra pockets.



Luminous disk to identify comrades in the dark



Colt .45 side-arm carried for quick access